FREE TOOLKIT

Theory of Change Toolkit

A practical template, a worked example and a donor-readiness check for foundations, NGOs and international organisations.

01 Why it matters

02 The template

03 Worked example

04 Donor-readiness check

Funders keep asking one question: why should this work?

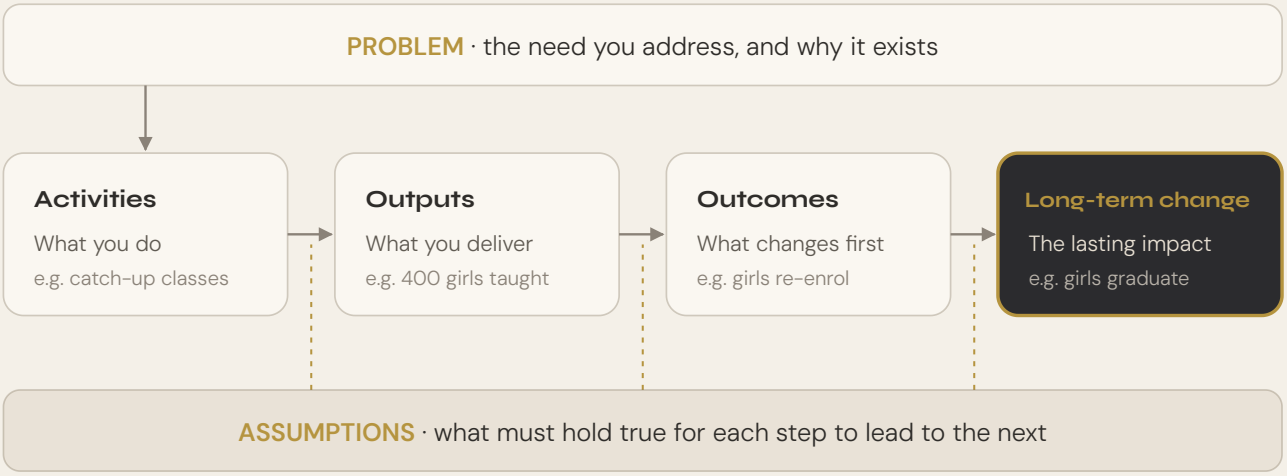
A theory of change is the logic that links what you do to the change you want to see. Foundations and institutional donors increasingly expect one in proposals and reports.

A strong theory of change shows that your programme rests on evidence, not hope. A weak one signals the opposite, however good the work is.

This toolkit is for programme leads, grant managers and directors. Use it to draft a first version, or to stress-test one you already have.

How it fits together

A theory of change is a chain of if-then links, from the problem to the lasting change you want.



Each link rests on assumptions. The weakest one sets the strength of the whole chain, which is why the template asks you to name them, then to back each step with indicators and evidence.

Map your theory of change

Work through each row in order. Write in plain language: if a board member could not follow it, a donor will not either.

BUILDING BLOCK	GUIDING QUESTION	YOUR ANSWER
Problem	What specific problem are you addressing, for whom, and where? What evidence shows it exists?	
Long-term change	What will be different for people in 5 to 10 years if you succeed?	
Outcomes	What changes in knowledge, behaviour, access or systems must happen first to get there?	
Outputs	What will your activities directly produce (people trained, services delivered, tools built)?	
Activities	What will you actually do?	
Assumptions	What must hold true for each step to lead to the next? What could break the chain?	
Indicators	How will you know each outcome is happening? What is your baseline and target?	
Evidence base	What research, data or past experience shows this pathway works?	

TIP

Start from the long-term change and work backwards to activities. Organisations that start from their existing activities tend to describe what they already do, not what change requires.

03 · WORKED EXAMPLE

Second Chance Learning

A fictional programme helping out-of-school adolescent girls return to education in a rural district. The figures are illustrative.

BUILDING BLOCK	EXAMPLE ANSWER
Problem	In the district, many girls aged 12 to 17 have left school, mainly because of household costs, early marriage pressure and the distance to secondary schools. A local assessment confirms the main drivers.
Long-term change	Girls in the district complete secondary education and have more choice over work and marriage.
Outcomes	Girls re-enrol and stay in school; families see education as worth the cost; schools adapt to returning learners.
Outputs	400 girls receive catch-up classes; 400 households receive cash transfers tied to attendance; 30 teachers trained in accelerated learning.
Activities	Run catch-up classes; deliver conditional cash transfers; train teachers; hold community dialogues with parents and religious leaders.
Assumptions	Cash transfers offset the main cost barrier; community leaders support girls' return; schools have space for returning learners.
Indicators	Re-enrolment rate (baseline 0, target 70% of participants); attendance over 80% after one year; share of parents who say education is worth the cost (baseline survey, then annual).
Evidence base	Evaluations of conditional cash transfers and accelerated learning in similar settings; the district assessment findings.

WHAT MAKES IT WORK

Each outcome traces back to a named barrier in the problem, and each assumption names something that could fail.

04 · DONOR-READINESS CHECK

Is your theory of change donor-ready?

Tick each statement that is fully true today. Be strict: "mostly" does not count.

01	☐	The problem is backed by recent data, not just experience or anecdote.
02	☐	The people you serve, or their representatives, helped shape it.
03	☐	Partners and key stakeholders agree with the pathway, not just your own team.
04	☐	Every outcome links clearly to a cause named in the problem.
05	☐	Your assumptions are written down, and you know which ones are riskiest.
06	☐	Each outcome has an indicator with a baseline and a target.
07	☐	You can say how much change the budget buys, for example cost per person reached.
08	☐	It reflects how change happens in your context, not a generic template.
09	☐	You have revisited it in the last 12 months using new data.
10	☐	Your leadership and board could explain it in two minutes.

Your score

8 – 10
Donor-ready. Keep testing your assumptions as new data comes in.

5 – 7
A solid base with gaps a reviewer will spot. Focus on evidence and stakeholder agreement.

0 – 4
It describes your activities more than your logic. Rebuild it with your partners before your next proposal.

BEFORE YOU SUBMIT

Five common pitfalls

01 **Activities dressed up as outcomes**

"200 people trained" is an output. The outcome is what those people now do differently.

02 **Hidden assumptions**

The weakest link is usually the one nobody wrote down, such as "communities will support this".

03 **Written by one person**

A theory of change drafted alone at a desk reflects one view. Reviewers notice when partners and communities are missing.

04 **Too generic**

If your theory of change could describe any programme in any country, it explains nothing about yours.

05 **Filed and forgotten**

It should change as your data does. One written for a proposal and never revisited quickly goes stale.

NEXT STEP

A theory of change your funders will back.

This template gives you the structure. The harder part is getting partners, communities and leadership to agree on the pathway, and testing it against evidence until it holds up to a donor. That is what SA Analytical does, combining data analysis with facilitated workshops.

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